

Ada Lovelace

The Girl Who Saw Possibilities

The true story of a girl who dreamed of flying machines, saw what a calculating machine could become, and wrote what we now call the first computer program.

Before reading

Look at the cover. What is young Ada holding up to her eye? What do you think the holes are for?

While reading

1. What did twelve-year-old Ada want to build? How did she plan it?
2. At the party, what did Ada want to know about Charles Babbage's machine?
3. How did the punched cards in weaving mills give Ada an idea?

After reading

1. Ada called her way of thinking "poetical science": imagination plus careful thinking. When do you use both?
2. Ada was ill for a long time but kept learning. What helps you keep going?
3. What would you like a machine to do one day?

The big idea

Imagine it. Plan it. Step by step!

Use it for any project, from a block tower to a birthday card: dream it up, plan the steps, then do them in order.

Try this together

Robot friend. Give a grown-up step-by-step instructions to walk to the door. They must do exactly what you say! What happens if a step is missing?

Words to talk about

machine · inventor · instructions · program · loom · pattern

Tips for reading aloud: pause on the pictures and let children notice details first. There are no wrong answers to these questions; follow your child's curiosity. The back of the book has four simple experiments to try, and a free activity pack is at tarkasatales.com/activities.

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